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LEADING THE ENDGAME
Amit Shah at a CRPF function in Madhya Pradesh

▶ NAXALISM

CLOSING THE RED CHAPTER

As Amit Shah declares victory over the six-decade-old Naxal insurgency, securing lasting peace is the next step

By RAHUL NORONHA

ON MARCH 30, CHELLURI NARAYANA RAO, alias Somanna, a Central Committee member of the banned Communist Party of India (Maoist), surrendered in Vijayawada after more than three decades in its ranks. He had been linked to multiple killings, including the 2018 assassination of an MLA and a former legislator on the Andhra Pradesh–Odisha border. A day earlier, in the forests of Sukma in neighbouring Chhattisgarh's Bastar region, Muchaki Kailash, a Maoist platoon section commander carrying a Rs 5 lakh bounty, was killed in a gunfight with security forces. He was among the dwindling number of armed cadres still active in these tribal areas.

Both developments came on the eve of March 31—the deadline set by Union home minister Amit Shah in August 2024 to eliminate left-wing extremism (LWE). In Parliament, on March 30, Shah declared that the country had "more or less" achieved that goal. "I can say without hesitation that we have become Naxal-free," he told the Lok Sabha in a nearly hour-and-a-half-long reply to a discussion on the issue, adding that formal processes would conclude shortly. Since 2024, 706 Naxals have been killed, 2,218 arrested and 4,839 have surrendered. Shah framed the outcome as the culmination of a calibrated strategy to counter the past mistakes. "Bastar was not engulfed by red terror because of the lack of development," he said. "Rather, it was the shadow of red terror that kept development out."